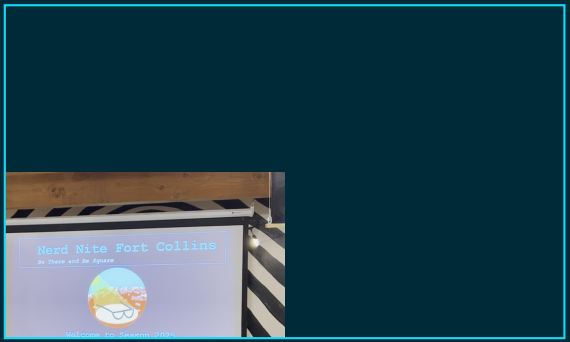
Nerd Nite Fort Collins

Be there and be square

You Had to be There



Justin Fritz

Boss, Nerd Nite Fort Collins

Nerd Nite Melbourne #71 • Howler, Brunswick • 14 October 2026

Hi. I'm Justin Fritz.

And I'm a Nerd Nite Boss.

That is a real title. They gave it to me. I take it very seriously.



I have had a lot of roles

Marine • navigator • instructor

chip designer • founder • host

As an American, I tend to conflate
the person with the job.

Tonight I am here as myself.
And as a Nerd Nite boss.



The relevant education

Not the classrooms.

In the field.

In the lab.

Frankly — at Nerd Nites.

PHOTO img/p04-field

One image for "the field or the lab" - a bench, a flight deck, a probe card, anything with his hands in it. Candid and specific beats illustrative.



PHOTO

img/p03-trajectories

Many separate tracks arriving at one point. Hand-drawn pencil lines on a chart, or long-exposure light trails. Flown, not plotted – not a tidy infographic.

Trajectories

Everything I just listed is a sampling of one trajectory.

Everyone in this room has a rich history.

Tonight ours came together here.

Thank you.



Talks. Mars. An abstract. An organ.



“You had to be there.”

the thing people say when the telling failed



Worst Party Ever

Everything You Didn't Know About the Donner Party

Hannah Bauer

NNFC S2025E01 30 January 2025



Nobody in that bar was in the Sierra Nevada in 1846.

For a moment they were.

Hector Berlioz Was a Visionary Composer and also a Creepy Stalker

Matt Browne

NNFC S2024E04 April 2024



Why did that just work?



PHOTO

img/p06-mars

A rover alone on Mars, empty horizon, no people and no Earth in frame. The emptiness is the argument - pick the loneliest public-domain NASA/JPL frame available.

We have not sent people

We sent probes. Rovers. Instruments.

They returned more data than anyone can read.

Somebody had a hypothesis before it ever launched.

Somebody else is reading it back.



The telemetry is complete.

The chronicle is not.



Worm Majix

John Anderson

NNFC S2025E08 18 September 2025

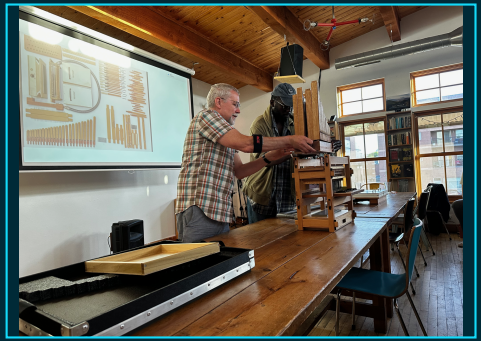
The abstract arrived rough.

Jamie started to fix it.

I stopped her.

We ran it exactly as offered.





Let's Build a Pipe Organ!

Joel Bacon

NNFC S2026E06 18 June 2026

Hundreds of parts.

Two octaves. Hand pumped. Mechanical action.

The audience built it.

Then he played it

A hand-pumped organ cannot make a sound unless somebody is standing there supplying the air.

We needed a volunteer.

Somebody put their hand up.



Thank you

The talks I borrowed tonight

Hannah Bauer — *Worst Party Ever*
Fort Collins, Jan 2025

Matt Browne — *Hector Berlioz*
Fort Collins, Apr 2024

John Anderson — *Worm Majix*
Fort Collins, Sep 2025

Joel Bacon — *Let's Build a Pipe Organ!*
Fort Collins, Jun 2026

And whoever pumped the organ.

Everyone who makes this happen

Nerd Nite Melbourne — Ebony, Haylo and the bosses

Nerd Nite Fort Collins — Senne Van Loon,
Jamie Fritz, Hannah Bauer, Marybeth Arcodia

Chris Balakrishnan and **Matt Wasowski**, who started it in a bar in Boston

Bosses in 100+ cities, every month

Every speaker who ever trusted a room with the thing they love most.

And especially — all of you.